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M: So Barbara, you're famous as a journalist and you've written nickel and diamond. Based on your research, could you start by telling us why you do secret investigations?

W: Sure, interviews are fine, but sometimes you need to experience it yourself. By putting yourself in the situation you're investigating, you can then write from a more informed point of view.

M: I see. So what did you do?

W: Well, I worked as a waitress, a hotel housekeeper, a nursing home assistant and a supermarket clerk. I spent a month in each low paid job, working in Florida, Maine and Minnesota.

M: Well, that's a lot of different jobs and places. What exactly did you find out?

W: Well, first the rents were very high and the wages were so low. Also, you have to be a hard worker. Interviewing people is one thing, but actually doing the job day to day shows you exactly how hard these people's lives are.

M: Hum and of course, Nickel and Diamond went on to be a very popular book. It was a New York Times bestseller.

W: Yes, I was really surprised at all the interest. I think it really opened people's eyes a first hand account like that. I hope my book can attract more attention so as to improve the situation of people in low paid jobs.